WEJ LAB

Evaluation Metrics

W. Evan Johnson, Ph.D.
Professor, Division of Infectious Disease
Director, Center for Data Science
Associate Director, Center for Biomedical Informatics and Health AI
Rutgers University – New Jersey Medical School

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Learning objectives

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Explain why we split data into training and test sets
- Compute overall accuracy and explain when it misleads
- Build and read a confusion matrix
- Define sensitivity, specificity, and related metrics
- Choose a metric that fits the biomedical question

Evaluation metrics

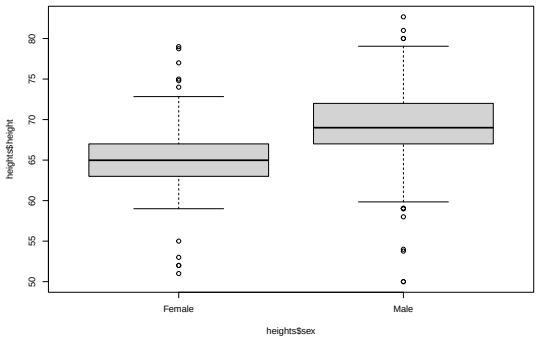
Before optimizing algorithms, we need to define what "better" means. We use `caret` and the `heights` data from dslabs.

```
library(tidyverse)
library(caret)
library(dslabs)
data(heights)
```

Evaluation metrics

Height by sex:

```
boxplot(heights$height~heights$sex)
```



Evaluation metrics

Simple example: predict sex from height.

```
y <- heights$sex
x <- heights$height
```

Evaluation metrics

- One predictor (height) and a categorical outcome (`Male`/`Female`)
- Heights overlap a lot, so we won't predict Y very accurately
- Can we beat guessing? We need a quantitative definition of "better"

Training and test sets

Algorithms are judged on new data. So we split the data:

- **Training set:** outcomes known; used to build the algorithm
- **Test set:** we pretend outcomes are unknown; used only to evaluate

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Training and test sets

`caret::createDataPartition` randomly splits the data:

```
set.seed(2007)
test_index <- createDataPartition(y, times = 1,
                                  p = 0.5, list = FALSE)
```

`times`: number of splits; `p`: proportion in the index; `list`: return a list or not.

Training and test sets

Define the two sets:

```
test_set <- heights[test_index, ]
train_set <- heights[-test_index, ]
```

Develop using **only** the training set, then **freeze** the algorithm and evaluate it on the test set. The simplest metric is **overall accuracy**.

Overall accuracy

The simplest possible algorithm: guess.

```
y_hat <- sample(c("Male", "Female"),
                length(test_index), replace = TRUE)
```

This ignores height entirely.

Overall accuracy

ML functions in R usually expect categorical outcomes as factors:

```
y_hat <- sample(c("Male", "Female"),
                length(test_index), replace = TRUE) %>%
  factor(levels = levels(test_set$sex))
```

Overall accuracy

Overall accuracy is the proportion predicted correctly:

```
mean(y_hat == test_set$sex)
```

```
## [1] 0.5104762
```

About 50%. We are guessing!

Overall accuracy

Can we do better? On average, males are slightly taller:

```
heights %>% group_by(sex) %>%
  summarize(mean(height), sd(height))
```

```
## # A tibble: 2 x 3
##   sex    `mean(height)` `sd(height)`
##   <fct>           <dbl>        <dbl>
## 1 Female           64.9         3.76
## 2 Male             69.3         3.61
```

Overall accuracy

Another simple rule: predict `Male` if height is above 62 inches (about two SDs below the average male):

```
y_hat <- ifelse(x > 62, "Male", "Female") %>%
  factor(levels = levels(test_set$sex))
```

Accuracy goes from 0.50 to about 0.80:

```
mean(y == y_hat)
```

```
## [1] 0.7933333
```

Overall accuracy

Can we pick a better cutoff than 62? Try several and keep the best.

Optimize the cutoff on the training set only: the test set is only for evaluation.

Overall accuracy

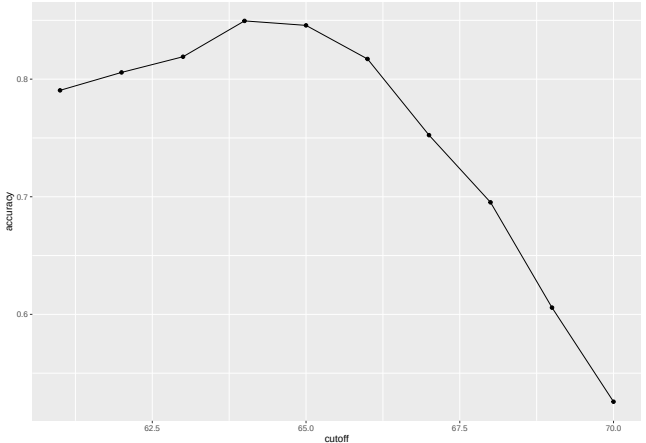
Training-set accuracy for 10 cutoffs:

```
cutoff <- seq(61, 70)
accuracy <- map_dbl(cutoff, function(x){
  y_hat <- ifelse(train_set$height > x, "Male", "Female") %>%
    factor(levels = levels(test_set$sex))
  mean(y_hat == train_set$sex)
})
```

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Overall accuracy

Training-set accuracy by cutoff:



Overall accuracy

The maximum accuracy:

```
max(accuracy)
```

```
## [1] 0.8495238
```

and its cutoff:

```
best_cutoff <- cutoff[which.max(accuracy)]
best_cutoff
```

```
## [1] 64
```

Overall accuracy

Check this cutoff on the test set, so the estimate isn't over-optimistic:

```
y_hat <- ifelse(test_set$height >
  best_cutoff,"Male","Female") %>%
  factor(levels = levels(test_set$sex))
mean(y_hat == test_set$sex)
```

```
## [1] 0.8038095
```

The confusion matrix

Overall accuracy can be deceptive. The *confusion matrix* tabulates predictions against truth:

```
table(predicted = y_hat, actual = test_set$sex)
```

```
##           actual
## predicted Female Male
##    Female     48   32
##    Male       71  374
```

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The confusion matrix

Accuracy computed separately by sex reveals a problem:

```
test_set %>%
  mutate(y_hat = y_hat) %>%
  group_by(sex) %>%
  summarize(accuracy = mean(y_hat == sex))
```

```
## # A tibble: 2 x 2
##   sex    accuracy
##   <fct>     <dbl>
## 1 Female    0.403
## 2 Male      0.921
```

The confusion matrix

Too many females are predicted male, because the **prevalence** of males is high:

```
prev <- mean(y == "Male")
prev
```

```
## [1] 0.7733333
```

The confusion matrix

In overall accuracy, the many errors for females are outweighed by correct calls for males. **This is a big problem in machine learning.**

Sensitivity and specificity

The four entries of the **confusion matrix**:

	Actually Positive	Actually Negative
Predicted positive	True positives (TP)	False positives (FP)
Predicted negative	False negatives (FN)	True negatives (TN)

Sensitivity and specificity

Sensitivity $= TP/(TP + FN)$: the proportion of actual positives called positive.

Also called the **true positive rate** (TPR) or **recall**.

Sensitivity and specificity

Specificity $= TN/(TN + FP)$: the proportion of actual negatives called negative.

Also called the **true negative rate** (TNR).

Sensitivity and specificity

Precision $= TP/(TP + FP)$: the proportion of predicted positives that are actually positive.

Also called **positive predictive value** (PPV). Unlike TPR and TNR, precision depends on prevalence: higher prevalence gives higher precision even when guessing.

Sensitivity and specificity

Summary of the terms:

Measure of	Name 1	Name 2	Definition	Probability representation
sensitivity	TPR	Recall	$\frac{TP}{TP+FN}$	$Pr(\hat{Y} = 1 \mid Y = 1)$
specificity	TNR	1-FPR	$\frac{TN}{TN+FP}$	$Pr(\hat{Y} = 0 \mid Y = 0)$
Precision	PPV		$\frac{TP}{TP+FP}$	$Pr(Y = 1 \mid \hat{Y} = 1)$

Here TPR is True Positive Rate, FPR is False Positive Rate, and PPV is Positive Predictive Value.

Sensitivity and specificity

`caret::confusionMatrix` computes all of these. It expects factors and treats the **first level** as positive ($Y = 1$); here that is `Female` (alphabetical).

```
cm <- confusionMatrix(data = y_hat,
                      reference = test_set$sex)
```

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Sensitivity and specificity

Access the metrics directly:

```
cm$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
##  Accuracy
## 0.8038095
```

```
cm$byClass[c("Sensitivity","Specificity", "Prevalence")]
```

```
## Sensitivity Specificity  Prevalence
##   0.4033613   0.9211823   0.2266667
```

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Sensitivity and specificity

Overall accuracy is high despite low sensitivity, because female prevalence is low (0.23).

Missing females (low sensitivity) costs less accuracy than missing males would (low specificity).

Summary

- Always evaluate on data the model has not seen
- Overall accuracy can hide poor performance when classes are imbalanced
- The confusion matrix underlies every classification metric
- Sensitivity and specificity trade off as the cutoff changes
- Pick metrics by the cost of each type of error (e.g., missed TB case vs. false alarm)

Session Info

```
sessionInfo()
```

```
## R version 4.5.2 (2025-10-31)
## Platform: aarch64-apple-darwin20
## Running under: macOS Tahoe 26.6.2
##
## Matrix products: default
## BLAS:   /System/Library/Frameworks/Accelerate.framework/Versions/A/Frameworks/vecLib.framework/Versions/A/libBLAS.dylib
## LAPACK: /Library/Frameworks/R.framework/Versions/4.5-arm64/Resources/lib/libRlapack.dylib;  LAPACK version 3.12.1
##
## locale:
## [1] en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8/C/en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8
##
## time zone: America/Denver
## tzcode source: internal
##
## attached base packages:
## [1] stats     graphics  grDevices utils     datasets  methods   base
##
## other attached packages:
##  [1] dslabs_0.9.1    caret_7.0-1     lattice_0.22-9  lubridate_1.9.5
##  [5] forcats_1.0.1   stringr_1.6.0   dplyr_1.2.1     purrr_1.2.2
##  [9] readr_2.2.0     tidyr_1.3.2     tibble_3.3.1    ggplot2_4.0.3
## [13] tidyverse_2.0.0
##
## loaded via a namespace (and not attached):
##  [1] tidyselect_1.2.1     viridisLite_0.4.3    timeDate_4052.112
##  [4] farver_2.1.2         S7_0.2.2             fastmap_1.2.0
```

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